

World in Brief: Burnham wins Makerfield by-election; Vance postpones talks with Iran



Photograph: Getty Images

Andy Burnham won a by-election in **Makerfield**, setting him up to challenge Sir Keir Starmer as leader of Britain’s Labour Party and therefore the country’s prime minister. Mr Burnham—who will step down as mayor of Greater Manchester before becoming an MP—secured 55% of the vote, comfortably beating Reform UK’s candidate, who took 35%. In a post-election speech, **Mr Burnham** said that this may be the Labour Party’s “final chance to change”.

J.D. Vance, America’s vice-president, delayed a planned trip to meet Iranian negotiators in Switzerland, citing logistical issues. They were set to discuss the implementation of the agreement signed by the presidents of America and Iran this week. Earlier Mr Vance scolded Israeli cabinet members for criticising Donald Trump’s deal. He said the American president is “the only head of state in the entire world” sympathetic to **Israel**.

Israel and **Hizbullah**, an Iran-backed militant group, continued to trade strikes in **Lebanon**, jeopardising the peace process between America and Iran. The agreement calls for an end to military operations “on all fronts, including in Lebanon”. At least 18 people were killed in Israeli airstrikes overnight, according to Lebanese

media. Israel said four of its soldiers were killed in southern Lebanon.

Mojtaba Khamenei, [Iran's supreme leader](#), wrote in a statement that Mr Trump agreed to a deal “out of desperation”. In-person negotiations with America do not mean “acceptance of the enemy’s position”, he added. Meanwhile, America lifted its naval blockade on the Strait of Hormuz; **petrol prices** in America fell below \$4 a gallon on average for the first time since March 30th.

Russia vowed to launch “massive” strikes against **Ukraine** in retaliation for a major drone attack on Wednesday evening and Thursday. Ukraine hit Moscow with nearly 200 drones, in its largest strike on the city so far, another demonstration of its ability to [reach deep](#) into Russia. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine’s president, said the strikes were a “fully justified response to Russian attacks on our cities and communities”.

Gunmen attacked **Niger’s** largest airport, killing 35 people before government forces secured the area. The West African country’s defence minister said 20 suspects had been arrested and 22 attackers were killed. JNIM, a local affiliate of al-Qaeda, claimed responsibility for the assault. It is the second time this year that gunmen have attacked the airport. [Niger](#) has battled an Islamist insurgency for a decade.

Intel stocks rose by almost 11% after Mr Trump said the company would partner with **Apple** to design and make semiconductors in America. The government bought a stake in the American chipmaker last year as part of its effort to bring production onshore. Meanwhile Apple warned that it would raise the prices of several products due to the [surging cost of inputs](#), including memory chips.

Figure of the day: \$22bn, the amount Fox paid, in cash and stock, for Roku, a streaming platform. [Read about how](#) the cable giant is planning to shake up the streaming wars.

US in Brief: Meet America's next socialist mayor



Photograph: AP

Janeese Lewis George won the Democratic primary for the mayor's race in Washington, DC. The 38-year-old's victory in November's election, which is almost certain, would continue a streak of mayoral victories for Democratic Socialists in big American cities, including Zohran Mamdani in New York and Katie Wilson in Seattle. Ms Lewis George's success in the primary will [upset Donald Trump](#): he has threatened to "take back" the capital and run it on a federal basis should she become mayor.

In **Maine**, Matt Dunlap, a left-wing Democrat, won the party's primary for a critical congressional seat. He will run against the state's former Republican governor, Paul LePage, in November. The Republicans spy a chance to flip the seat after the Democratic incumbent, Jared Golden, said he would not seek re-election. Meanwhile, Hannah Pingree won the Democratic nomination for the governor's race after a run-off, and will face Bobby Charles, a MAGA Republican.

Republican criticism of Mr Trump's interim deal with Iran intensified, even as the White House delivered the document to Congress. The Republican chair of the Senate Armed Forces Committee, Roger Wicker, said the agreement "negotiates away the victories" of the war, particularly with the creation of a \$300bn

reconstruction fund for Iran. J.D. Vance, the vice-president, defended the deal and called it a “win for the American people”.

Pete Hegseth, the defence secretary, said the Pentagon would begin a six-month review into the deployment of [American forces in Europe](#). He also once again lashed out at NATO allies over their defence spending and response to Mr Trump’s war in Iran. In May America said it would withdraw 5,000 troops from Germany. The comments set the stage for an awkward NATO summit in Turkey next month.

No talks between Vance and Iran, for now



Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

With one deal done, it should be time to negotiate the next—but not yet, it seems. J.D. Vance, America’s vice-president, had been due to meet Iranian officials in Switzerland on Friday. Their talks were to be a first step towards implementing the accord signed by both countries’ presidents this week. But the meeting was called off at the last minute. Mr Vance cited logistical issues: “These negotiations have never been simple or predictable,” said his spokesperson. Some reports suggest the Iranian delegates stayed home to protest against Israeli strikes in Lebanon.

The abrupt cancellation is an early example of how difficult it will be for America and Iran to reach a final accord, which they are meant to do within 60 days. Donald Trump tried twice before to clinch a nuclear pact with Iran. Both attempts ended in failure (and war). The lead negotiators on both sides—the speaker of Iran’s parliament, and Mr Vance—are relatively pragmatic. But anything they agree on is likely to prove controversial at home—even more than the process has already.

The mystery of Aung San Suu Kyi



Photograph: Shutterstock

Aung San Suu Kyi turned 81 on Friday. Jailed after the army ousted her government in a coup in 2021, the former de facto leader of [Myanmar](#) is being held in solitary confinement as part of a 27-year prison sentence on fabricated charges. After the junta rigged recent elections, a few political prisoners were released, but not Ms Suu Kyi. It is not known where she is, or even whether she is alive. Myanmar's state-controlled media reports that she was recently moved from prison to "house arrest". But her supporters are sceptical.

Her son, Kim Aris, is leading a worldwide campaign to demand an independently verified "proof of life". To attract attention to his mother's plight he has skateboarded 81km in London. Despite losing international respect after she defended her country when it was accused of genocide against the Rohingya, she remains popular among her fellow Burmese. Alive or dead, she casts a long shadow over Myanmar.

Can Reliance tempt investors back to India?



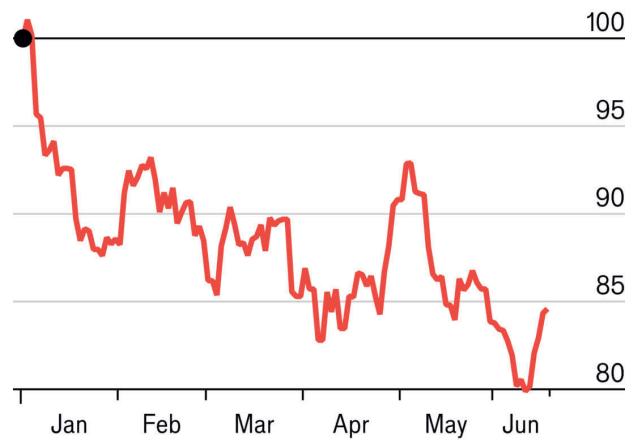
Photograph: Reuters

Reliance, one of India's biggest conglomerates, holds its annual general meeting on Friday. The firm, run by [Mukesh Ambani](#), Asia's second-richest man, has had a tough year. Its colossal oil refinery depends on imports of the fuel—prices of which have surged in recent months. The peace deal between America and Iran may inject some optimism into the meeting.

So could an announcement of plans for the listing of Jio. Since Reliance's telecoms arm launched in 2016, it has driven India's smartphone revolution, providing cheap data to hundreds of millions. If the listing goes ahead, it is expected to raise \$4bn, making it India's biggest. Following a run of bumper years for listings, there have been few Indian IPOs in 2026 as many were put on hold when the Iran war knocked investors' confidence. Markets have suffered, too, as foreign investors have ditched Indian equities in favour of those from Asian countries with big AI firms. Plans like this could be just what the public markets need.

Unreliable

Reliance Industries, share price,
Jan 1st 2026=100



Source: LSEG Workspace

North Korea tries to build bridges



Photograph: Getty Images

The first road bridge connecting Russia and North Korea was supposed to open on Friday to mark the two-year anniversary of the countries' mutual-defence treaty. But satellite imagery shows construction is unfinished on the Russian side of the Tumen river. The delay is but a hiccup in their plans for closer transport links. Rail traffic between the two countries has picked up; direct flights between Moscow and Pyongyang resumed last year.

In part, this reflects the growing number of Russian tourists flocking to North Korea, and North Korean workers toiling in Russia. But military co-operation is at the heart of [their closer](#) relationship. North Korea has supported Russia's war in Ukraine with thousands of troops and shipments of artillery shells, missiles and rockets. In return it has received advanced technologies, food and cash. The cosiness has even brought North Korea a new friend: Belarus. The hermit kingdom will be glad to have another dictatorship in its Rolodex.

Netflix will find you



Photograph: Netflix

Should you open Netflix this week, the words “I WILL FIND YOU” will appear. They feel more like a threat than a title: “Harlan Coben’s I WILL FIND YOU” is the latest series based on the novels of Mr Coben, an American thriller writer. Previous adaptations have proved popular. In 2024 Harlan Coben’s “Fool Me Once” was watched for almost a quarter of a billion hours in the week of its release.

Mr Coben’s nail-biters are packed full of mysteries: missing daughters, vanished wives, lost husbands. They offer meta-mysteries too, like: how do the characters, who have such ordinary jobs, have such extraordinary kitchens? And: why is Netflix so fixated on Mr Coben? Above all: why does his name get such prominent billing, when another author, called [Jane Austen](#), often appears in much smaller font? At least Mr Coben can clear that last one up. An early series, he says, sounded too much like another, so to differentiate “they put my name above the title”.

Daily Quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: What great event began at a bakery in Pudding Lane in 1666?

Thursday: Who was nominated for his role as best supporting actor in the film "Sideways"?

Ambition: it is the last infirmity of noble minds.

J.M. Barrie